



H O R S D ' O E U V R E S | D I L I P B O B B

Forever Young



Angelina Jolie in *Tomb Raiders* endures as a male fantasy, which is appropriate since it involved the search for the ultimate fantasy, the Holy Grail, symbolising immortality. Grant anyone a single wish and they will ask to live forever, not fame, money or power. Science has never been closer to the so-called Methuselah Pill (he's the biblical guy who lived for 969 years). Stem cells, nano-technology, genetics and organ transplants have given unprecedented hope to those who "rage against the dying of the light". Life expectancy has risen dramatically and some scientists like American futurist Ray Kurzweil predict that man could become immortal in as little as 20 years through new age-defying aids. A Leeds University project aims to help people to live to a hundred with bodies of 50 year-olds by replacing body parts. That's a scary thought. There is nothing more seductive than physical immortality (sorry Angelina). Yet, as in every seduction, the downside is conveniently blurred. There is every possibility that our enjoyment of those extra years would be marred by disabilities. The success of science has created a paradox which offers a longer life but with more life-diminishing diseases. Only recently have scientists focused on the diseases of the elderly. Moreover, there is no procedure that keeps the brain young.

More to the point, it would eliminate the generational touchstones in our lives: marriage, kids, their marriage, grandkids.

Francis Fukuyama warns in his new book that the new young will "refuse to get

out of the way; not just of their children, but their grandchildren and great grandchildren". Also, If 80 becomes the new 40, there will be no retirement age, limiting the scope for new talent, new ideas and young blood. Stephen Dubner of *Freakonomics* fame says that age may actually become a new barometer of status. "There will be too many older people with too much market power, too much political influence, too much momentum," he says. Here's another thought. If we live to over 100, are we going to have just one partner for all that time? The social fallout is unimaginable. As Daniel Callahan, head of a leading think tank says, "There is no known social good coming from the conquest of death. The worst possible way to resolve this issue is to leave it up to individual choice." There is also the question of resources. Global population would surge. The planet is already fast approaching a point where there are too many people consuming too few resources. Ultimately, the end of days sharpens our focus. Everything is more beautiful because we're doomed.

SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com

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SIGNPOSTS

AWARDED: To Najam Sethi, former Editor-in-Chief of the *Daily Times* in Pakistan, the 2009 Golden Pen of Freedom, for reporting and investigating as an independent



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journalist despite threats. The award was given by the World Association of Newspapers and News Publishers in Hyderabad.

WON: By INDIA TODAY Special Correspondent Shyam Lal Yadav, the National RTI award given by PCRF-NDTV. Yadav was among 1,130 nominees and is the only media representative to have won the award. The award is in recognition of path-breaking investigative stories done on the back of information gathered by INDIA TODAY.



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